

Open Source browsers

Google Chrome is based on Open Source software, Chromium which has no branding and auto-update mechanism from Google.

Clearing misconceptions

That Open Source software is free of cost is a misconception. Many Linux distributions such as Mandriva, OpenSUSE and RedHat offer alternate paid versions.

In addition, it involved the setting up of email with school-specific domains and encouraging the use of Microsoft Office Live Workspace to streamline the process of collaboration between different users.

This move received flak from several free software purists, who believed that something as important as technical education for the masses can't be left to an organisation like Microsoft, whose interests were mainly commercial. Furthermore, the MoU made the use of Microsoft software mandatory, which was in direct opposition to the Open Standards that had been established by the FOSS community. In a letter to the Secretary of School Education Sanjay Kumar, the Free Software Foundation of India wrote, "The State cannot allow products of only one private company to be utilised, and must instead actively engage with and promote FOSS which is based on principles which are consonant with our democratic polity." The letter along with many others, raised several concerns over the MoU, including the high cost of proprietary software which would ultimately have to be borne by the students and the responsibility of the government in setting up Open Standards in technology that benefit the public.

It also demonstrated how the Kerala government had incorporated FOSS philosophy into their education system with the IT @ School programme. The programme replaced Microsoft Windows with the free Linux operating system on close to 50,000 desktops in 2,800 schools. This led to its teachers and students becoming ICT literate, and savings of more than ₹50 crores over the past couple of years.

In a major victory for the proponents of free software, the Department of Information Technology (DIT) in 2010,



Prakash Advani

finalised its policy on Open Standards for e-governance, wherein it stated that all e-governance projects must adhere to a single set of Open Standards, and these standards

would be made available 'royalty-free'. In an article on opensource.com, Venkatesh Hariharan applauded this move of the government and highlighted important features of the policy:

1. The government is spending more than \$10 billion on e-governance projects, and enforcing open, royalty-free standards would imply major savings.
2. Due to the volume of data processed by the e-governance solutions, the adoption of these standards would make them popular throughout the world.
3. As the volume of data stored went up, protecting its integrity would become crucial. In this regard, using proprietary software would give the vendor enormous control over the agreement.
4. It also calls for defining and implementing a single standard, which would ensure uniformity and ease of integration when dealing with data from different state governments.

Final thoughts

Many such initiatives have been undertaken by the NRCFOSS and its associates to provide various low-cost solutions in numerous projects across the country. One of the most ambitious projects, the UID project – which aims to provide a unique identity to more than 700 million Indians – will benefit from the Open Standards adopted by the Government. Projects that call for storage and processing of large amounts of data, decision-making in critical situations and automation of tasks that were manually handled all use software that is Open Source.

Indian IT firms have benefitted immensely from the Open Source model, and Indian developers have contributed extensively to popular projects like GNOME and KDE. DimDim (a video-conferencing tool) and Zoho (a complete web-based office suite) are among India's popular Open Source offerings. FOSS has proved to be an excellent alternative (OpenOffice in place of Microsoft Office and Ubuntu in place of Microsoft Windows) to many SMBs who have recorded significant savings after making the switch. Co-Founder of the IndLinux project and Regional Head, Asia-Pacific

SAAS

Software as a Service

Relatively new, SaaS is a software delivery model, wherein the software is provided to client by the vendor on an on-demand basis. The software and its data is usually hosted by the vendor's server, and clients access it through an application like a web browser. The benefits of this model are lowered costs, constantly updated version of the software, platform independence and data security. However, drawbacks include lack of customisation by the client, not having enough control over data and always requiring a network connection to the server. SaaS is another low-cost alternative to proprietary software. In fact, very often SaaS relies on Open Source technologies to create reliable back-ends as well as to keep the cost of the service low. However, SaaS vendors usually don't share the source code of the software back with the client, making it 'closed source'.

of Canonical, Prakash Advani stated, "Today Ubuntu has been able to create an impact by providing a good option as a free operating system. It's been widely deployed in India and growing very quickly." On the topic of businesses and institutions that have made the switch to Open Source, Advani said that "With re-use of code, the Open Source model has a low cost of development. Indian software companies can hence reduce their cost of development and increase profitability. Meanwhile, the IITs are big users of Open Source. Some others that we know of are: Rishi Valley school, SNDT College, Guru Nanak Dev University Ludhiana and Delhi University. Many of the engineering colleges around India are running Open Source/Linux labs." Former President of India of India Dr. APJ Abdul Kalam also believed that FOSS would play a critical role in promoting growth of IT in developing nations like ours. Indeed, the low costs and the community-driven nature offered by FOSS, as well as the establishment of open standards in IT are all contributing significantly towards India's social, economic and technological prosperity. ■